inclusion of the vast majority of modern Eastern Europe was even more evident.

Of course, there was no Western or Eastern Europe in the time of Charlemagne. To the Franks, the Slavs and Magyars were simply those (usually violent) invaders that needed to be dealt with in some way. Christianisation – even though in part carried out at sword-point – was a surprisingly civilised method of containing the Slavic (and later Magyar) menace, at least by the standards of the early Middle Ages. In some way, it was akin to the enlargement process of the European Union. To Christianise Slavs also meant turning them into allies, and allies – at least Christian allies – do not fight against each other. This stopped the advance of the Slav hordes but also made violence against them, now they were Christian, less acceptable morally. The new alliances also implied that, sooner or later, since they were at a lower level of political organisation, Slavs would be subdued by those who had already achieved a higher version of statehood, as the Franks had. It would, of course, be very premature to see in this any form of nationalism: the world of Charlemagne was not a world of ethnicities and even less so one of nations. It was a simple fact that, at a point when Christianity was gaining popularity, the Franks (as proto-Germans or proto-French or proto-Europeans) were at a stage of political organisation which allowed the use (and misuse) of Christian religion for political purposes. For the Slavs to opt for Christianity may have meant an uncertain political future (although would there be any more certainty in confronting the Franks militarily?) but it also meant becoming a part of ‘Europe’; a part of the globalisation of the Middle Ages.

One can only speculate about how much this globalisation was controversial at the time. How far the decision to accept Christianity was a conscious one is difficult to say, even for the Slavic rulers.[8] On the other hand, some historians believe that it was not all about worldly interests, and that leaders such as Charlemagne were guided by genuine religious zeal.[9]

The fact is that, culturally speaking, Christianisation gave the Slavs the first written texts in their own languages, facilitated access to the ‘science’ and arts of the day (at least to those very few at the time who could read and write) and generally brought them into the family of Christian nations, a sort of EU of the day. To expand the Kingdom of God in a faster and easier way, the missionaries made use of teaching and preaching in the vernacular,